

In another life, Curtis Thompson would have been an American footballer.

In an even more unlikely alternate world, where Thompson leaned further into his maternal heritage, he could have been a badminton player — a curious scenario, considering he is a six-foot-tall, 102-kilo American of Jamaican descent.

But in this reality, Thompson thrives as a professional javelin thrower, ranked among the world's best. As we reach the midpoint of the year, he sits third in the global standings, behind Germany's Julian Weber and India's Neeraj Chopra.

Only two Americans have ever thrown farther than Thompson — and many believe he could finally end the nation's 50-year wait for an Olympic javelin medal.

Still, things could have gone very differently. Growing up in New Jersey, he explored a variety of sports with restless curiosity — including badminton thanks to a family connection.

"My mom's side is from Jamaica, and there were a few who played badminton, which is one of the sports we played at cookouts or get-togethers," says Thompson over a video call from Alabama.

"Outside of playing football, I also tried basketball and baseball. I gave soccer a try when I was little, but didn't like it. And then when I got to high school, I played basketball, football and track.

"Over the years, I would drop one sport. I stopped basketball after my second year of high school. And then after my third year, I stopped playing football and just focused on javelin," he says.

He traces the transition to a serendipitous moment in high school, when he initially took up track to improve his football speed. One day, disillusioned by the repetition of sprint drills, he walked over to the javelin coach and asked, "Can I throw that stick thing?"

That throw sparked a chain reaction. He quickly surged through the ranks, establishing himself as the top javelin thrower in the country.

"By the end of my junior year, I had gone over 200 feet and became the number one US thrower at that time. That was the moment I realised I am good at it," says Thompson.

He was also nudged toward javelin by the toll football was taking on his body.

"Football is a very rough sport. It's a lot of contact. And once I started javelin and saw the path, I just stuck with it. I knew that was going to be what I would do in college and beyond. I realised javelin is kinder than football, health-wise," he adds.

Like many javelin throwers, YouTube was his first coach.

"To start, it was a lot of YouTube. After a year, I went to a javelin clinic and gained some technical ideas. First, it was just get out there and throw it. The clinic allowed me to learn. Slowly, I added small technical things over and over," he says.

After cutting his teeth on the national circuit and entering the global stage, Thompson's breakthrough came in 2023 when he won gold at the Pan American Games.

In 2025, he raised his level with a personal best throw of 87.76m in Texas — the world-leading mark for nearly two months before Neeraj and Weber overtook it.

Thompson credits that throw to finding his "zone."

"It was one of those days where everything kind of hit right. There was less thinking going into it; it was more of reacting."

One of the keys to his recent improvement has been switching from the American grip to the Finnish one — the preferred choice of many elite throwers globally. The Finnish grip, with an extended index finger, offers more control and power.

"I was curious about it and decided to go Finnish. It just worked for me right at the beginning of the season. So I kind of just stuck with it."

#### **Coach Curtis**

From an Indian lens, shaped by the underfunded nature of athletics, the USA might appear to offer abundant opportunity. But for a niche sport like javelin, the trickle-down effect hasn't fully taken hold. Even for someone as accomplished as Thompson, making ends meet is a challenge.

"You have to figure out how to pay bills, on top of funding your season. We do have athletes who get support from the government, which is great. But it's tough on the development side if you're not quite at that level.

"You have to work those jobs to make money so that you can attend meets. I'm hoping that before my career is done, it will